

Message 1

An Introductory Word and the Secret Care of the Hiding God for His Oppressed Elect in Their Dispersion

Scripture Reading: Esth. 1; Esth. 2

With this message we begin the life-study of the book of Esther. Esther is a sweet book, covering, as its central subject, the secret care and the open salvation of the hiding God in Israel's captivity. God is omnipresent and also omnipotent, yet He is hiding. Nobody knows where He is.

The people of Israel had been scattered, dispersed, in their captivity. They probably told the Gentiles among whom they were living that their God was Jehovah. Gentiles, especially the rulers, might have said to the Israelites, "Where is your Jehovah? Is your Jehovah real and living? If He is, why are you here in captivity as slaves?" During the years of the captivity, God was hiding, and He is still hiding. Even today, in the church age, God is hiding Himself. Both for the children of Israel and for us today, it seems that there is no God in this universe. We need to realize that God is living and real, but He is hiding. He is a God who hides Himself (Isa. 45:15).

Because God's people became degraded and rotten, God disciplined and punished them by handing them over as slaves to the Gentile nations. Yet in His severity there is mercy (Rom. 11:22). While the people of Israel were in dispersion and captivity, God was taking care of them in a hidden way, and at the right time He came in openly to save them. Even when the captives of Israel were in the lowest situation, at the bottom, Christ was among them, suffering with them (Zech. 1:7-17).

On the one hand, God used the Gentile nations as tools to discipline His people. On the other hand, the hiding God was with the people of Israel, caring for them. Eventually, God used the Medo-Persian Empire to overthrow the Babylonian Empire. Cyrus, the king of Persia, was even called God's shepherd, one who would fulfill His desire (Isa. 44:28), and His anointed, one who would serve God's purpose (45:1-4). From this we see that the hiding God did many things for Israel in a secret way.

I. An introductory word

Let us now consider some introductory matters.

A. The writer

The writer of the book of Esther was most probably Mordecai (Esth. 9:20, 23). As Esther's cousin, he was the one who raised her.

B. The time

The contents of this book cover a period of at least ten years during the reign of Ahasuerus (486-465 B.C.).

C. The contents

The book of Esther gives us a vivid record of how the hiding God of Israel took care secretly of His oppressed elect in their dispersion and saved openly His persecuted elect in their captivity.

D. The crucial point

The crucial point of Esther is that the very God who chose Israel, the descendants of Abraham, as His elect, after He gave them into captivity to the Gentile nations, became a hidden God to them to take care of them secretly and save them openly in secrecy (Isa. 45:15). This is the reason that this book does not mention the name of God even at occasions when the name of God should be mentioned (Esth. 4:3, 16). Because this book shows us a hidden God, it does not mention the name of God.

E. The sections

The book of Esther has two sections: (1) the secret care of the hiding God for His oppressed elect in their dispersion (chs. 1—2) and (2) the open salvation of the hiding God in secrecy to His persecuted elect in their captivity (chs. 3—10).

II. The secret care of the hiding God for His oppressed elect in their dispersion as seen in Esther

Chapters one and two unveil the secret care of the hiding God for His oppressed elect as seen in Esther.

A. Establishing a top king in the Gentile world

First, the hiding God established a top king in the Gentile world in prosperity, power, and glory over a great empire extending from India to Ethiopia (Africa) — 1:1-2.

B. Causing the top king to depose his queen because of her disobedience to his word

Next, the hiding God caused the top king to depose his queen because of her disobedience to his word at his great banquet with his high officials (vv. 3-22). The king commanded that the queen come before him wearing the royal crown in order that he might present her to those attending the banquet. However, the queen refused to come at the king's command. As a result of her disobedience the queen was deposed, and the position of queen became vacant.

C. Raising up a Jewish orphan virgin to be crowned by the top king as his queen

Finally, in His secret care the hiding God raised up Esther, a Jewish orphan virgin, to be crowned by the top king as his queen (2:1-18). Esther saved the king from being assassinated, telling the king in Mordecai's name of those who planned to assassinate him (vv. 19-23).

Our God is omnipresent, omnipotent, merciful, and full of forgiveness. Although He is such a God, He is also the hiding God. Because our God is a hiding God, others may check with us and ask, "Where is your God? Where is His kingdom?" When we are questioned in such a manner, we may want to answer in this way: "My God is hidden. I cannot see Him, and you cannot see Him either. But you need to realize that sooner or later my hidden God will come in to do something on my behalf and to deal with those who do not believe in Him."

I can testify concerning this from my experience. More than forty-five years ago, I, along with several other co-workers, was arrested and imprisoned by a small Chinese army that betrayed China and worked for the Japanese military police. The entire Christian community in that city was shocked, because they knew that we could very easily be executed like other Chinese who had fallen into the hands of the Japanese invading army. We did not know what to expect, but the hiding God intervened in a wonderful way using a particular person as an Esther.

The wife of the captain of the Chinese army under the Japanese military police had been the wife of a schoolmate of mine who had died of tuberculosis. When he was dying, his wife asked me to visit him, and I did so and had an intimate conversation with him. He eventually died, and some time later she remarried. After I was arrested and imprisoned, a medical doctor who was meeting both with us and with other Christians heard about my situation. He then went to speak to the woman who had married the captain of that Chinese army. The two were close friends, and the doctor who was meeting with us told the woman that I and several others had been imprisoned and that she should ask her husband to release us. She spoke to her husband about us that very day. He loved her and was willing to fulfill her request.

That night he appeared to judge our case. We were taken from our cells and stood before him to be judged. I was the first one to be examined by him. He looked at me, asked me my name, and told me that everything was all right and that I was free to go home peacefully. He said the same thing to the others who had been arrested with me. At the time none of us knew what had taken place behind the scene. Later I realized that, in His secret wisdom, the hiding God had prepared an Esther for us. He had raised up a Chinese widow to become the wife of the man who would judge our case. Just as the king of Persia listened to Esther and did what she said out of his love for her, so this man listened to his wife and released us from prison. This surely was due to the care of the hiding God.

Today we need to realize that the omnipotent God whom we are serving is still hiding Himself, especially when He is helping us. We cannot see Him, and apparently He is not doing anything for us. Actually, He is with us all the time and, in a hidden way, He is doing many things for us.

The Open Salvation of the Hiding God in Secrecy to His Persecuted Elect in Their Captivity

Scripture Reading: Esth. 3; Esth. 4; Esth. 5; Esth. 6; Esth. 7; Esth. 8; Esth. 9; Esth. 10

In this message we will cover chapters three through ten.

III. The open salvation of the hiding God in secrecy to His persecuted elect in their captivity as seen in Mordecai

These chapters are concerned with the open salvation of the hiding God in secrecy to His persecuted elect in their captivity as seen in Mordecai.

A. Haman's plot to destroy all the Jews in Medo-Persia

In chapter three we see Haman's plot to destroy all the Jews in Medo-Persia.

1. An agagite by the name of Haman being promoted to the highest seat above all the princes who were with the king

The Agagites were enemies of God. God charged Saul to slay all the Agagites, but he failed to do this and thereby offended God.

An Agagite by the name of Haman was promoted (no doubt at the instigation of Satan, the adversary of God) to the highest seat above all the princes who were with the king. The king commanded all his servants to bow down and pay homage to Haman, but Mordecai did not bow down or pay homage because of his Jewish belief in the unique God (vv. 1-4). He believed in one God and refused to bow down to anyone other than God.

2. Haman being filled with rage and plotting not only to kill Mordecai but also to destroy all the Jews throughout the empire

Haman was filled with rage and plotted not only to kill Mordecai, the one who refused to pay him homage, but also to destroy all the Jews throughout the empire. He had the king send a decree to each province of his empire to destroy all the Jews, both young and old, children and women, in one day, the thirteenth day of the twelfth month, and to plunder their spoil (vv. 5-15). Haman's evil intention was to destroy all the Jews and to take away their wealth.

B. Mordecai's confrontation of Haman's plot through Esther's close and intimate contact with the king

In 4:1 through 8:2 we have an account of Mordecai's confrontation of Haman's plot through Esther's close and intimate contact with the king.

1. All the Jews and Esther fasting

When all the Jews and Esther heard of what Haman intended to do and learned that the king had even issued a decree to carry out Haman's intention, they fasted (4:3, 16). Although they fasted for their supplication to God, contrary to what we would expect, in verse 16 there is no mention of the name of God. While Esther and all the Jews were fasting, Haman, under the plot with his wife and friends, made a gallows on which to hang Mordecai (5:9-14).

2. The king being unable to sleep and finding the report of how Mordecai had saved him

The king could not sleep, so he gave orders to have the book of the records of the chronicles brought, and they were read before him (6:1). The king found in the records the report of how Mordecai had saved him from being assassinated by two of his eunuchs, and he decided to bestow honor and dignity on Mordecai. While the king was considering this, Haman came into the court to ask the king about hanging Mordecai (vv. 2-6). The king was thinking about honoring Mordecai, and Haman was thinking about hanging him. When the king asked Haman what should be done for the man whom the king desires to honor, Haman answered, "Let a royal robe be brought, one which the king has worn, and a horse on which the king has ridden and on whose head a royal crown has been set. And let the robe and the horse be delivered into the hand of one of the king's most noble princes; and let them array the man whom the king desires to honor and make him ride on horseback through the street of the city; and let them proclaim before him, Thus shall it be done for the man whom the king desires to honor" (vv. 8-9). At this juncture, the king commanded Haman to put on Mordecai a royal robe which the king had worn, make Mordecai ride through the street of the city on a horse on which the king had ridden, and proclaim before Mordecai, "Thus shall it be done for the man whom the king desires to honor" (vv. 10-11). After Haman did this, he hurried to his house, mourning and with his head covered (v. 12).

3. Esther pointing out to the king that haman was the wicked adversary and enemy who conspired to kill all the Jews

At her feast with the king and Haman, Esther the queen pointed out that Haman was the wicked adversary and enemy who conspired to kill all the Jews. The king immediately sentenced Haman to death and commanded his men to hang Haman on the gallows which he had prepared for Mordecai. On that day the king gave the house of Haman, the enemy of the Jews, to Esther the queen and took off his signet ring, which he had taken from Haman, and gave it to Mordecai, making him the second man to the king in the whole empire (7:1—8:2).

C. The open, triumphant victory of the Jews over their enemies

In 8:3 through 10:3 we see the open, triumphant victory of the Jews over their enemies — the open salvation of their hiding God to rescue them from their persecutors.

1. The king issuing a decree through Mordecai

The king issued through Mordecai a decree to authorize the Jews to destroy all their enemies throughout his empire from India to Ethiopia, one hundred twenty-seven provinces (8:3-14).

2. The Jews having light, gladness, joy, and honor

Mordecai went forth from the presence of the king in royal robes of blue and white and with a large crown of gold and a garment of fine linen and purple. The city of Susa the capital shouted and rejoiced, and the Jews had light, gladness, joy, and honor. Throughout every province and every city, wherever the king's decree came, the Jews had gladness, joy, a feast, and a good day. Many from among the peoples of the land (the heathen) became Jews, for the fear of the Jews had fallen on them (vv. 15-17).

3. The Jews destroying all their enemies throughout the empire

The Jews destroyed all their enemies throughout the empire under the reign of King Ahasuerus in the influence of Esther the queen with Mordecai as the second to the king (9:1-16). All the princes of the provinces, the satraps, the governors, and those who did the king's business helped the Jews because of the fear of Mordecai, who was great in the king's house and whose fame went forth throughout all the provinces and who became greater and greater (vv. 1-4). In Susa the capital in two days the Jews destroyed eight hundred of their enemies and they hanged Haman's ten sons upon the gallows (vv. 5-15). In the provinces the Jews assembled and destroyed seventy-five thousand of those who hated them, thus having rest from their enemies (v. 16).

4. The triumphant Jews appointing and establishing the days of Purim

The triumphant Jews appointed and established the fourteenth and fifteenth days of the month Adar as the Purim to celebrate their triumphant victory over their enemies (vv. 17-32). In this way the feast of Purim was established among the Jews for the remembrance and celebration of the two days during which they destroyed their enemies throughout the great empire of Persia. These days were to be days of feasting and rejoicing and of sending portions to one another and gifts to the poor (vv. 17-19, 22). These days were to be remembered and kept throughout every generation, every family, every province, and every city, and the remembrance of them was not to fade from their seed (vv. 26-28). The appointment and the establishment of the Purim was confirmed by Queen Esther and Mordecai the Jew in writing with all authority (vv. 29-32).

5. Mordecai becoming second to King Ahasuerus and great among the Jews

Mordecai became second to King Ahasuerus and great among the Jews and well-regarded by the multitude of his brothers, one who sought the good of his people and who spoke for the welfare of all his seed, that is, all the children of Israel (10:1-3).

IV. A concluding word

A. A crucial hidden point

The story of the book of Esther is a crucial hidden point for the fulfillment of God's calling to Abraham for a land, a seed (a people), and the blessing to all the nations (Gen. 12:1-3; 22:17-18).

B. For the fulfillment of the promise through Moses

The story of this book is also for the fulfillment of the promise through Moses that after God gave Israel into captivity, He would still take care of them (Deut. 4:27-31).

C. For the fulfillment of the prayer of Solomon

In addition, the story of the book of Esther is for the fulfillment of the prayer of Solomon on the day of the dedication of the temple that God would take care of His elect in their captivity (1 Kings 8:46-53).

D. For the keeping of the lineage of the genealogy of Christ

Moreover, the story recorded in the book of Esther is also for the keeping of the lineage of the genealogy of Christ through the survival of Israel in their captivity that Christ might be brought into the human race. If all the Jews had been destroyed, there would have been no lineage of Christ's genealogy for Christ to be brought into humanity.

E. To keep a people for the possessing of the holy land for the coming kingdom of Christ

Finally, the story of the book of Esther is to keep a people for the possessing of the holy land for the coming kingdom of Christ. The people of God's elect who returned from captivity were small in number, yet they occupied and possessed at least a small portion of the earth, the holy land. This was significant because the earth had been usurped by Satan, and there seemed to be nothing left for the God of heaven and earth. However, God brought back a small number of His people to possess the holy land as a base for Christ to come back to establish His kingdom on earth.

The eschatology of the church according to the divine revelation of the Scriptures

Scripture Reading: Rev. 17:1-6, 16; 14:8; Matt. 13:37-42; 1 Cor. 3:9-15; Rev. 21:1-11, 18-21

We need to see that there is not only an eschatology of the world, the study of the end of the world situation, but also an eschatology of the church. Our study of this crucial matter is according to the divine revelation of the Scriptures. We believers in Christ are not only in the world but also in the church. The genuine church exists within Christianity. Christianity has become very great and includes mainly the Catholic Church and the Protestant church. The Catholic Church and the Protestant church were not there at the time of the apostle Paul. What was there at his time was the original and recovered church. The recovered church refers to the original church. These two are one.

Paul rebuked the Corinthian believers in his first Epistle to them by telling them that they were trying to divide Christ. There were various parties in Corinth who were saying, "I am of Paul," "I am of Apollos," and "I am of Cephas." The self-supposed "spiritual" ones said, "I am of Christ" (1:12-13a). Thus, there were four divisions in Corinth. The church in Corinth was an original church, but it had degraded; it had lost something. At that juncture Paul wrote them. His Epistles to them were recovery books; they recovered the church in Corinth.

By reading Paul's second Epistle to Timothy, we can also see that at Paul's time the church had degraded. Some had left the Christian faith. Others, like Alexander the coppersmith, opposed Paul to the uttermost (4:14). But Paul himself declared that he had kept the faith (v. 7). Second Timothy is a book of recovery. The original church existed only for about half a century. The apostles established the original church within less than fifty years. But while Peter, John, and Paul were still living, the church fell from its original state to a degraded state, a deformed state, and even a transmuted state. This is why the Epistles were written. All the "second" letters of Peter, John, and Paul (e.g., 2 Peter, 2 and 3 John, 2 Corinthians, etc.) were letters of recovery. All these letters were for recovering the lost church.

At John's time, some even said that Christ never came in the flesh (1 John 4:2-3; 2 John 1:7). Others said that Christ was not the Son of God but eventually became the Son of God (1 John 2:22-23). The church had become deformed, changed in form, and transmuted, changed in nature. Thus, John wrote to the believers to recover them. At the time of the apostles we can see the original and recovered church.

The recovered church came into being just a little later than the original church. The original church lasted only for a short time. It was born into a sick situation, an unhealthy environment. When the apostle Paul was sent by the Holy Spirit from Antioch to Asia to preach the gospel and to set up churches, the opposing Jews came to frustrate him. After the churches were established, the Gnostics came in to make trouble. Thus, the church became sick either from Judaism or Gnosticism. The original church did not last too long, but God would not let the church be lost without any kind of recovery. This is why the Lord as the Head of the Body charged the apostles Peter, John, and Paul to write their later Epistles to recover the church. We have to realize that the Lord's recovery began at the end of the first century. In every century afterward, the Lord raised up a number of "Ezras" and "Nehemiahs" to recover, to reconstitute, the church.

In the first five centuries, there was only the original and recovered church. Then near the end of the sixth century the Catholic Church came into existence. At that time the pope was recognized as the authority of the Catholic Church. The Protestant church came into existence at the time of Martin Luther during the Reformation in the sixteenth century. Today there are still these three kinds of churches.

The church of the recovery is always taking a narrow way. All of those who participate in the recovered church learn the special lessons in the Christian life. They learn to know Christ, to know themselves, and to know the flesh. They learn how to be crucified to live the God-man life. All the members of the church should be God-men because the church is formed with the deified man. The high truth of God becoming a man that man might become God in life and nature but not in the Godhead was discovered by the church fathers in the second century. This was something of the Lord's recovery. With us the Lord's recovery began in mainland China seventy-two years ago. Today there are mainly three kinds of churches on earth: the Catholic Church, the Protestant church, and the original and recovered church. We must choose the original and recovered church because it is genuine.

The real condition and end of the Catholic Church

The real condition and end of the Catholic Church are clearly unveiled in Revelation 17. The first six verses tell us the condition, and the last three verses tell us the end. The condition is illustrated in a figure of speech by a golden cup (v. 4). A cup signifies something that is presented to a person for him to drink to meet his need. The golden cup signifies that in outward appearance the apostate church does have something of God. The Catholic Church believes that Christ is God, that He was born of a virgin, and that He died for the sins of sinners and resurrected. In their recent catechism, they also pointed out that God became a man that man might become God. In today's Protestant churches, on the other hand, there are modernists who do not believe that Christ is God, that He was born of a virgin, and that He died on the cross as the Redeemer. They consider that Christ was a martyr and do not believe that He resurrected.

In Revelation 17 the Roman Catholic Church is called "MYSTERY, BABYLON THE GREAT" (v. 5). There are even some Catholic scholars who have recognized that the Great Babylon in Revelation 17 refers to the Catholic Church. In Matthew 13 the Lord likened the Roman Catholic Church to a woman who took leaven and put it into fine flour (v. 33). Most fundamental expositors of the Bible say that the fine flour refers to Christ as food to both God and man. Leaven signifies evil things (1 Cor. 5:6, 8) and evil doctrines (Matt. 16:6, 11-12). It includes all evil things such as heresy, idolatry, and adultery. Thus, the Catholic Church is a mixture.

The cup which the woman has in her hand is golden, but it is full of abominations and the unclean things of her fornication (Rev. 17:4). In figure, gold signifies the divine nature of God. Hence, the apostate church does have something of God, but she is full of evil things such as heresies, idolatry, pagan practices, spiritual fornication, and even physical fornication. For a woman to practice fornication means that she has many husbands. The church should be married to Christ and to the truth of the Bible. Not only is Christ the Husband, but also the truth, the Word of God, is the Husband. The Word of God and Christ are one. The Catholic Church has accepted Christ and the Word of God, yet it has also received many heresies and idols. This has made her a spiritual fornicator.

The Catholic cathedrals are full of idols. G. H. Pember pointed out that one of the saints in the Roman Catholic Church is actually Buddha (see the Life-study of Revelation, Message 51, p. 585). In Manila there is a statue of a so-called Jesus at the entrance of a certain cathedral. The feet of this statue have been touched and even kissed by people so many times that there is a hole there. This is idolatry, but it is in a "golden cup."

One young person from a Catholic family received the Lord Jesus and then went to his parents to tell them that he had the Lord Jesus in him. His parents responded by saying that they already had Jesus, and they pointed to a picture of the so-called Jesus hanging on the wall. Because they had such a picture, they thought they had Jesus.

In 1937 when I was traveling in the interior of China, a case of demon possession was brought to my attention. I said that in principle either sin or some idols or images in that woman's home would give the ground for demon possession. Eventually, I learned that on her wall was a picture of the so-called Jesus, and I told her to burn it. From the moment she burned that picture, the demon departed. The Catholic Church is full of idols, heresy, and all kinds of pagan and heathen practices. This is the real condition of today's Catholic Church.

Revelation 17 also tells us the end of the Catholic Church. At the end of this age, the Antichrist will make a covenant with the Jews for seven years. In the middle part of this seven-year period, he will break this covenant (Dan. 9:27) and exalt "himself above all that is called God or an object of worship" (2 Thes. 2:4). He will persecute all religions, and the first religion persecuted by him will be that of the Catholic Church. This is because both Antichrist and the Catholic Church will be centered in Rome. Revelation 17:16 says, "And the ten horns which you saw and the beast, these will hate the harlot and will make her desolate and naked and will eat her flesh and burn her utterly with fire." This means that Antichrist and his ten kings will persecute the Great Babylon and burn her. That will be the end of the Catholic Church.

The general condition and end of the protestant church

The Protestant church is full of false believers (Matt. 13:37-42). In Matthew 13 the Lord told us that the kingdom of the heavens is like a man who sowed good seed of wheat in his field, but his enemy then came and sowed tares in the midst of the wheat. His slaves then asked if they should go to collect these tares. But the man's response was, "Let both grow together until the harvest, and at the time of the harvest I will say to the reapers, Collect first the tares and bind them into bundles to burn them up, but the wheat gather into my barn" (v. 30). The Lord said that at the consummation of this age, He will send His angels to collect all these tares, signifying all the false, nominal Christians in any kind of church, and will cast them into the lake of fire (vv. 40-42). They will be thrown directly into the lake of fire, having no need to pass through the formality of any judgment. Their end will be the same as Antichrist and the false prophet. Both of them will also be thrown into the lake of fire directly, without any formal judgment (Rev. 19:20).

The genuine condition and end of the original and recovered church

The original and recovered church is the genuine church. The church in Corinth was a genuine church. Paul told them, "You are God's cultivated land, God's building" (1 Cor. 3:9). He was telling them that they were the genuine believers, the real ones who had received the Lord Jesus, who had been regenerated, and who were going to be sanctified, renewed, transformed, conformed, and glorified. On the one hand, they were God's farm to grow Christ. On the other hand, they had to be transformed from plant life to minerals. They had to grow so that they could be transformed to become gold, silver, and precious stones, the material for God's building. Paul laid the unique foundation of Christ, but the believers' progress would depend upon how they grew and how they built upon this foundation. If they built with wood, grass, and stubble, these materials would be burned (vv. 10-13).

At His coming back, the Lord will judge and deal with not only the Catholic Church and the Protestant church but also the original and recovered church. He will summon all His genuine believers in any kind of church to His judgment seat (2 Cor. 5:10; Rom. 14:10; 1 Cor. 4:5) to be judged and dealt with by Him. In that judgment He will discern whether they have built with gold, silver, and precious stones or with wood, grass, and stubble. The work of wood, grass, and stubble will be consumed, and those who have worked with these worthless materials "will be saved, yet so as through fire" (1 Cor. 3:15). On the other hand, those who have built with gold, silver, and precious stones will be the materials for the constitution of the New Jerusalem in the millennium and be consummated in the New Jerusalem in the new heaven and new earth.

At the Lord's coming back, the overcomers who are transformed into gold, silver, and precious stones will be awarded to be in the New Jerusalem in the thousand years of the kingdom. Revelation shows us that the New Jerusalem will be the Paradise of God in the thousand years for the overcomers (2:7). But those who produce wood, grass, and stubble will have their work burned at the Lord's coming back, and they will be saved as through fire. They will be disciplined by the Lord for one thousand years. Eventually, through the Lord's patience, they will be perfected and transformed also into precious material for God's building. At the end of the thousand years, they will also join and participate in the New Jerusalem in its consummation. This is the genuine condition and end of the original and recovered church.

Today we have a choice as to which way we will take. Will we take the Catholic way, the Protestant way, or the original and recovered way? If we take the original and recovered way, how will we take it? Will we take it in a condition of idleness? Revelation shows us that among all the genuine believers, only those who are like Paul in struggling to pursue Christ will gain and enjoy Christ. They will be the overcomers. We may be in the original and recovered church, but what kind of condition are we in? Are we endeavoring to be the overcomers to close this age? In other words, are we endeavoring to live a God-man life with ourselves and our flesh always being crucified on the cross that we may live by His divine life to express Christ? If so, we will be able to proclaim, "For to me to live is Christ. I live to magnify Christ whether through life or death by the bountiful supply of the Spirit of Jesus Christ."

We should be such overcomers who are living and magnifying Christ day by day. We should be constituted as those who pursue Christ at any cost, always forgetting the past and going forward to gain Christ. To gain Christ actually means to live and magnify Christ. We can live and magnify Christ by living a crucified life toward ourselves, our flesh, our natural life, and everything other than Christ. We are crucified in every way to live Christ by the bountiful supply of the Spirit of Jesus Christ. Then we not only live Him but also magnify Him. How much we gain Him depends upon how much we magnify Him. This is the living of the God-men, who are the overcomers.

We should not say in a light way that we are God-men. This is not a light matter. We may praise the Lord for the highest peak of the divine revelation that God has become a man that man may become God in life and in nature but not in the Godhead. But we should say, "Lord, I need Your mercy. I need Your abounding grace. Otherwise, how could I become God in life and in nature? Every day I need to live a crucified life to gain Christ, to magnify Christ."

The New Jerusalem as the ultimate consummation of God's eternal intention

Eventually, we will be in the ultimate consummation of God's purpose, the New Jerusalem (Rev. 21:1-11). The New Jerusalem is constituted with three kinds of materials: gold, pearl, and precious stones (vv. 18-21). Gold signifies God in His divine nature, pearl signifies the redeeming and regenerating Christ, and precious stones signify the transforming Spirit. This is the consummated Divine Trinity constituting Himself into our being to make us gold, pearl, and precious stones that He may have an enlargement for His eternal expression, the New Jerusalem.